

70 THOUSAND

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE KILLED BY BOUDICCA'S ARMY DURING THE ICENI REVOLT

WHEN CLAUDIUS DIED IN 54, the Roman imperial throne fell to **Nero** (37-68), his adopted son and son-in-law. The young emperor's reign began well when he promised the senate he would avoid making any arbitrary measures. However, the first sign of Nero's tyranny surfaced in 59, when he had his mother **Agrippina** (15-59) murdered. In 62, a new praetorian prefect (commander of the imperial bodyguard), **Tigellinus** (c. 10-69), took office. Tigellinus pandered to the less desirable side of Nero's personality, whose rule became increasingly despotic. Following a **fire** that destroyed much of Rome in 64, Nero is said to have taken terrible retribution on Rome's small Christian population, who proved convenient scapegoats. Later, during the reconstruction of Rome, Nero alienated senators by seizing their land to build himself a new palace. He also ordered additional taxes in Palestine, which sparked a **Jewish revolt** in 66.

In **Britain**, the Romans faced a serious **ICeni** revolt in 60. When the king of the Iceni died, he left his lands to his queen, **Boudicca**. The revolt was triggered when

the Roman procurator (chief financial official) ruled that Boudicca could not inherit her lands, and that they would be annexed by Rome.

Boudicca raised an army and marched on Camulodunum (Colchester).

Suetonius Paullinus, the governor of

Britain, was away on campaign in Wales, and by the time he returned, Camulodunum had been sacked by the Iceni. The rebels then burned Londinium (London) and Verulamium (St. Albans) before they were finally trapped and defeated by Paullinus. It is said the Iceni lost 80,000 warriors and Boudicca herself was captured, though she died, possibly poisoned, soon after.

Boudicca

This statue of Boudicca stands outside the Houses of Parliament in London, a city that the Iceni queen razed to the ground.



The ruins at Masada, the last outpost of the Jewish revolt against the Romans, which began in 66.

IN THE EAST, Rome faced further troubles with **Parthia** over the border region of **Armenia**, where the Parthian king had installed his own candidate, **Tiridates**, as king in 53. A Roman force invaded Armenia in 59, took its capital cities of Artaxata and Tigranocerta and put in place a pro-Roman king, **Tigranes VI**. His ill-advised invasion of a Parthian ally in 61 led to his removal, and Tiridates was restored. A new Roman army was then roundly beaten by the Parthians in 62, and only a Roman push into Armenia the following year ended the war.

Tiridates was allowed to keep the throne, as long as he travelled to Rome to seek Nero's approval, which he eventually did in 66.

Nero's position as emperor became increasingly precarious when **Calpurnius Piso** led a conspiracy in 64, which prompted Nero to order further executions, including those of many senators. In early 68, a revolt broke out, led by

Gaius Julius Vindex, governor of Gallia Lugdunensis.

Shortly after the revolt of Vindex, the legion based in Spain proclaimed the governor, **Sulpicius**

Galba, as emperor. Vindex's revolt was put down by **Verginius Rufus**, the governor of Germany, but **Nero** panicked and **committed suicide**, believing Rufus would be the next to try to claim his throne.

After Nero's suicide, four men became emperor in rapid succession, making 69 the "**Year of the Four Emperors**." First, the praetorian guard recognized **Galba** (3 BCE-69 CE) as emperor, but he made himself unpopular by refusing to give the praetorians the donative, a customary bonus payable on the accession of a new emperor. In January 69, the governor of Upper Germany, **Aulus Vitellius**, revolted, and one of Galba's former supporters, **Salvius Otho** (32-69), angered when Galba recognized another senator as his heir, had the emperor murdered and took the throne. In April 69, the armies of Otho and Vitellius clashed at Bedriacum near Cremona in northern Italy, and the Vitellian army won. Otho committed suicide, but Vitellius soon faced a further conspiracy when T. Flavius Vespasianus

960

COMMITTED
SUICIDE

7

Survivors

Roman invasion

When the Romans finally breached the walls of Masada, all except seven defenders committed suicide rather than fall into Roman hands.

51 Romans capture Caractacus, leader of the British resistance

52 Saint Paul begins spreading Christianity in Greece

57 An ambassador from Japan arrives at the Han capital of Luoyang

59 Suetonius Paulinus becomes governor of Britain

c. 60 Mark begins writing the first of the gospels recounting the life of Jesus Christ

c. 60 Kushans under Kujula Kadphises advance into northern India, starting the Kushan Empire

60 Nero sends an expedition to explore Meroe on the east bank of the Nile

60 The Iceni revolt against the Romans in Britain

63 Peace of Rhadeia between Rome and Parthia; Tiridates is returned to the Armenian throne

64 Great Fire of Rome; Nero blames the Christians and many are martyred

c. 65 Buddhism reaches China

66-70 Jewish revolt against Roman rule